



PEOPLE cast ballots in early voting Monday at the L.A. County registrar-recorder's office in Norwalk.

Outrage brings end to Trump scheme

The \$1.8 billion for 'anti-weaponization' faced legal setbacks and a GOP revolt.

By ANA CEBALLOS

WASHINGTON — The Trump administration is backing away from plans to create a \$1.8-billion fund to compensate people who claim the government was weaponized against them, a retreat that comes amid a cascade of legal setbacks and a revolt within members of the Republican Party.

But Senate Democrats say the concession is not enough, and are pushing legislation to ensure no president can ever attempt the creation of such a fund again.

"If Republicans are serious about ending this brazenly corrupt scheme, they should have no problem voting for legislation banning any president from creating such a slush fund in the future," Sen. Adam Schiff (D-Calif.) wrote Monday in a post on X.

Senate Minority Leader Chuck Schumer (D-N.Y.) added that Democrats plan to force a vote on a measure to ensure that Trump and Republicans are "truly abandoning this corrupt scheme."

"Trump's word is nowhere near enough," Schumer wrote on X. Earlier in the day, Schumer vowed to force a floor vote to make Republican lawmakers take a public stance on the issue.

Schiff, along with Sens. Mark Kelly of Arizona and Elissa Slotkin of Michigan, introduced the "Drain the [See Fund, A7]

Steyer and Hilton scrap for the second top spot

The two make their closing pitches while taking shots at gubernatorial front-runner Becerra

By Seema Mehta, Nicole Nixon and Dakota Smith

As Californians dawdle about casting ballots before Tuesday's primary, the leading candidates hoping to succeed Gov. Gavin Newsom crisscrossed the state making their closing arguments to voters.

With Democrat and former Biden Cabinet secretary Xavier Becerra surging in recent polls, the two candidates battling to win the second spot in the primary and advance to the November election highlighted the strategic reasons why they believe voters ought to support them.

Republican Steve Hilton — a former conservative commentator who rocketed past his main GOP rival,

Riverside County Sheriff Chad Bianco, after President Trump endorsed him in April — urged voters to back him to avoid the possibility of two Democrats facing off in November.

"I want us to fight like we are third. We aren't going to let this slip away," Hilton told a few hundred people at the Hilton Santa Monica Hotel & Suites on Sunday.

The former British political strategist once led the polls but has slipped slightly behind Becerra. Not far behind Hilton is Democrat Tom Steyer, a billionaire hedge fund founder turned climate change activist.

During his hour-and-a-half appearance, Hilton

veered between his oft-repeated criticisms about 16 years of Democrat-led rule in California to take jabs at the top Democrats in the race.

Steyer's nonstop advertising blitz is "one reason alone to defeat him," while Becerra is the "living embodiment of more of the same."

"Our secret weapon? The Democrat candidates," Hilton said to chuckles.

Steyer, who has spent a record-breaking \$216 million of his wealth on his gubernatorial bid, argued that he is the only candidate in the race who is not beholden to special interests. He ham-

[See Primary, A8]

World Cup matches in the U.S. are declared no-drone zones

Unmanned aircraft are increasingly used as weapons around the world

By RICHARD WINTON



JASON ARMOND Los Angeles Times

EIGHT World Cup matches will be held at SoFi Stadium in Inglewood, with the first slated for June 12.

In the run-up to the opening World Cup match in Los Angeles next week, authorities on Monday announced a series of security measures — including a no-drone zone at all venues nationwide, with officials saying they will take down any unauthorized flying objects.

Federal officials have been scrambling to get countermeasures in place as drones increasingly are being used as weapons of war and terror. Inglewood's SoFi Stadium will host eight matches during the FIFA World Cup 2026, ending with a quarterfinal match July 10. Both the U.S. national team and the team from Iran, whose countries remain at war, will be playing at the venue.

Patrick Grandy, an FBI assistant director who over-

[See Drones, A7]

Poll finds split on confidence in elections

Most Democrats say local balloting is fair.

With no proof of fraud, GOP voters disagree.

By KEVIN RECTOR

California voters are deeply divided over the trustworthiness of state elections heading into Tuesday's primary, with most Democrats but less than half of Republicans expressing confidence in the electoral process, according to a new poll.

The polarized view follows a years-long campaign by President Trump and his Republican allies to question the legitimacy of American elections, especially in California and other blue states. It also follows robust efforts from liberal leaders, elections officials and voting rights experts to denounce Trump's claims as baseless.

Overall, registered voters in the state — which skews heavily Democratic — expressed confidence in local election officials by a 2-to-1 margin, with 65% expressing confidence and 31% expressing a lack of confidence, according to the poll released

Tuesday by the UC Berkeley Institute of Governmental Studies and co-sponsored by The Times.

However, those figures shift dramatically when sorted by political party, and even more when parsed by partisan leaning.

For example, 79% of Democratic voters expressed confidence in local officials running a secure and fair election, compared with 62% of independent voters and 42% of Republican voters, the poll found.

While 82% of voters who identified as strongly liberal expressed confidence, just 38% of voters who identified as strongly conservative did so.

"It's clearly a partisan issue, and it is being promoted by the president and others who are his followers," said Mark DiCamillo, the director of Berkeley IGS polls. "Strong conservatives and the Republicans are the least confident, and a lot of them are saying [they are] not at all confident. That's a pretty extreme statement."

Rick Hasen, an election law expert and director of the Safeguarding Democracy Project at UCLA Law, said he expected Republi-

[See Poll, A8]

Data center ban goes before voters

Monterey Park hopes to set precedent as the first city to use ballot box to bar such sites.

By BLANCA BEGERT

Residents in the city of Monterey Park will be the first in the nation Tuesday to vote on a permanent ban on data centers.

If approved, Measure NDC would prohibit data centers within the city limits and could be overturned only by another vote.

Yard signs saying "No Data Center" in English and Chinese with images of dragons line sidewalks in the San Gabriel Valley city.

As a wave of data center opposition sweeps the country, numerous towns and counties across the U.S. have instituted temporary moratoriums and other restrictions on the facilities. But only a handful have instituted indefinite bans, and just four other towns have

sent related matters to the ballot.

Supporters are hoping the vote will set a precedent for the rest of the region, where residents are fighting proposals in Vernon and City of Industry.

"This is about as permanent a ban as we can get," said Steven Kung, co-founder of the group No Data Center Monterey Park. "Winning Measure NDC would send a huge message to the rest of the San Gabriel Valley about how residents don't want data centers."

The ballot measure emerged from the fight against a 247,000-square-foot center proposed in 2024 by the Australian-owned investment firm HMC StratCap for a residential area in Monterey Park.

The facility would have been located less than 500 feet away from the nearest home and used three times the electricity of the 60,000-person, predominantly Asian American city.

Although the developer

[See Data centers, A6]

Israel will intensify attacks, target Beirut

Netanyahu's campaign against Hezbollah had mostly skirted the Lebanese capital.

By NABIH BULOS

BEIRUT — The Israeli infantrymen advanced up to the hilltop in the dead of night, punching their way in a bare-knuckle, eyeball-to-eyeball fight against entrenched defenders until they reached their target:

Beaufort castle.

It was June 6, 1982, and by its end and many casualties later, Israeli troops raised the flag over the hilltop Crusader castle, marking the start of Israel's 18-year occupation of southern Lebanon.

Almost exactly 44 years since that night — and just over 26 years after a Hezbollah-led insurgency forced them to withdraw — Israeli troops blitzed into Beaufort once more, even as Israeli leaders press on with a campaign that could see a fifth of Lebanon under renewed in-

vasion.

On Monday, one day after Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu declared Beaufort's reconquest as "a dramatic change" in policy that would push Israel to "deepen and expand our hold on places that were under Hezbollah's control," he ordered Israel's military to attack targets in the Lebanese capital, Beirut.

The move canceled one of the few tangible achievements of a U.S.-brokered ceasefire between Hezbollah and Israel announced on

April 17. Though it did not stop Israeli attacks in Lebanon's south — where some 800 people have been killed since the ceasefire came into effect — nor Hezbollah fire on northern Israel, the truce had mostly excluded Beirut and its environs.

Israel's intensifying Lebanon campaign threatened the already shaky ceasefire between Washington and Iran, but President Trump announced that he had persuaded Israel to dial back its offensive.

[See Lebanon, A3]



JEFF DEAN Associated Press

RAMS GO ALL-IN AGAIN

They make a blockbuster trade for Browns' star defensive end Myles Garrett in latest bold move to capture another Super Bowl title. **SPORTS, B10**

L.A. runs short on green space

The city has more area devoted to parking spaces than to parks, Patt Morrison writes. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather
Some sun.
L.A. Basin: 77/59. **B6**

Markets **A13**
Opinion Voices **A14**

Anthropic files to list its shares

The move heats up an ongoing competition with much larger rival OpenAI. **BUSINESS, A11**

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